

Martin Heidegger, *Basic Concepts of Aristotelian Philosophy*

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§17. Ἑξις.

(*Metaphysics* 23 and 20, *Nicomachean Ethics* 1–5)
Book pp. 116–128 · PDF pp. 131–143

Orienting Thesis of §17

§17 is the ontological pivot of Chapter 3 of the First Part. Having shown in §15–16 that ἦθος (*ēthos*, “character”) and πάθος (*pathos*, “being-affected”) function as πίστεις (*pisteis*, “means of credence”) in Aristotle’s *Rhetoric*, Heidegger now argues that the proper grasp of πάθος (*pathos*) requires a prior grasp of ἑξις (*hexis*, “having,” “composure,” “being-composed-as-to”). His thesis: ἑξις (*hexis*) is not a “habit” in the ordinary moralistic sense, but a *fundamental concept of being*—the determination of the genuineness of being-there in a moment of being-composed as to something (p. 119). The four senses of ἔχειν (*echein*, “to have”) in *Metaphysics* Δ 23 all converge on a single ontological structure: *being after a definite being-possibility, or its negation*. Αρετή (*aretē*, “virtue,” “excellence”) is then articulated as ἑξις προαιρετική (*hexis proairetikē*, “a being-composed in the ability-to-resolve-oneself”), structured as μεσότης (*mesotēs*, “mean”) and oriented toward καιρός (*kairos*, “the right moment”). The result is an analysis of human being-there as *temporally cultivated composure*—a 1924 anticipation of the temporality and historicity of *Being and Time*.

§17a. Ἐχειν (*echein*) and Ἑξις (*hexis*)

pp. 116–119

The Methodological Opening

Heidegger transitions from §16 by carrying forward a decisive insight: πάθος (*pathos*) “already has within itself the relation to ἑξις (*hexis*)” (p. 116). The two concepts “lend themselves to being characterized by Aristotle as *fundamental concepts of being*.” Πάθος (*pathos*) is indicated as a being-concept since πάσχειν (*paschein*, “to undergo”)—in contrast to ποιεῖν (*poiein*, “to do”)—represents a basic aspect of the analysis of κίνησις (*kinēsis*, “motion”), of being in the sense of being-moved. Ἑξις (*hexis*) refers back to ἔχειν (*echein*, “to have”)—and Aristotle himself recognizes ἔχειν (*echein*) as a mode of being, as is shown by the fact that it appears among the ten categories.

“Ἐχειν (*echein*) is the being-structure to be set forth in the two salient phenomena, πάθος (*pathos*) and ἑξις (*hexis*).” (p. 116)

The Four Senses of ἔχειν (*echein*) in *Metaphysics* Δ 23

Aristotle says, by way of introduction, that τὸ ἔχειν λέγεται πολλαχῶς (*to echein legetai pollachōs*, “‘having’ is said in many ways”)—but the meanings are “not an arbitrary jumble” (p. 116): they relate to a basic meaning that becomes visible by working through the individual senses.

1.

(*agein kata tēn hautou physin ē kata tēn hautou hormēn*, “leading according to one’s own nature or impulse”)

“τὸ ἀγεῖν κατὰ τὴν αὐτοῦ φύσιν ἢ κατὰ τὴν αὐτοῦ ὁρμήν, διὸ λέγεται πυρετός τε ἔχειν τὸν ἄνθρωπον καὶ οἱ τύραννοι τὰς πόλεις καὶ τὴν ἐσθῆτα οἱ ἀμπεχόμενοι” (*Met.* Δ23, 1023a 8)

Translation: “leading according to its own fully determined possibility of being-there—φύσις (*physis*, ‘nature’)—or according to the impetus that is lying within the beings in question as such.” Heidegger’s examples (Aristotle’s): “fever *has the person* [sickness has attacked him ‘whom it has’ or ‘whom it has seized’]; the tyrants *have the towns* [they rule over them]; the ones who are dressed *have clothes* (ὄν).” This first sense is ἔχειν (*echein*) in the sense of ἀγεῖν (*agein*, “leading,” “directing”)—directing according to φύσις (*physis*) or ὁρμή (*hormē*, “impulse,” “impetus”).

2.

(*en hō an hyparchē hōs dektikō*, “in which something is present as in that which is receptive”)

“ἔν ᾧ ἂν ὑπάρχη ὡς δεκτικῶ, οἷον ὁ χαλκὸς ἔχει τὸ εἶδος τοῦ ἀνδριάντος καὶ τὴν νόσον τὸ σῶμα” (*Met.* Δ23, 1023a 11)

Translation: “*The metal has the look of a statue* [has the look, *is* a statue]. The body has the illness [it *is* sick].” The more precise determination of this sense of *having* is *being*: in itself something is present, “for which being-present the being in question itself has the readiness (δεκτικόν, *dektikon*)” (p. 117). The metal is determined as metal on account of the δεκτικόν (*dektikon*, “the receptive,” “the able-to-take-in”); it is determined in its being such that it can become a statue.

Heidegger now makes a crucial conceptual disambiguation:

“The metal is determined as ὕλη (*hylē*, ‘matter’). In this context, ὕλη (*hylē*) does not mean an indeterminate ‘material,’ but rather *a positive character of a mode of being-there*. Being in preparedness for ... is a positive determination of a being. Having means nothing other than being the wherein of a being-present of something out of preparedness.” (p. 117)

This is one of the most ontologically significant passages in §17: ὕλη (*hylē*) is not “stuff” awaiting form—it is *being-in-preparedness*, an active mode of being-there. [Note: this positive sense of ὕλη (*hylē*) will return, in transformed shape, in §18d, where ὕλη (*hylē*) of the πάθη [*pathē*] is identified with σῶμα (*sōma*, “body,” corporeality).]

3.

(*hōs to periechon ta periechomena*, “as that which contains what is contained”)

“ὥς τὸ περιέχον τὰ περιεχόμενα: ἐν ᾧ γὰρ ἐστὶ περιεχόμενόν τι, ἔχεσθαι ὑπὸ τούτου λέγεται, οἷον τὴν ὑγρὸν ἔχειν τὸ ἀγγεῖόν φαμεν καὶ τὴν πόλιν ἀνθρώπους καὶ τὴν ναῦν ναύτας: οὕτω δὲ καὶ τὸ ὅλον ἔχειν τὰ μέρη”
(*Met.* Δ23, 1023a 13)

Translation: “The enclosing has that which is enclosed [in the sense of containing, of being all around it]; wherein something is as contained therein, of which we say that something is had from the start, as the basin has, or contains, water, the town has people, the ship has sailors. In this way too the whole has parts.” Being-part “is always being-part-of-something, part of a whole, belonging to something. The whole is the wherein of the determinate belongingness of a part” (p. 118).

4.

(*to kōlyon kata tēn hautou hormēn ti kineisthai ē prattein*, “hindering something from being-moved or acting according to its own impulse”)

“ἐτι τὸ κωλύον κατὰ τὴν αὐτοῦ ὁρμὴν τι κινεῖσθαι ἢ πράττειν ἔχειν λέγεται τοῦτο αὐτό, οἷον καὶ οἱ κίονες οἱ ἐπικείμενα βάρη, καὶ ὡς οἱ ποιηταὶ τὸν Ἀτλαντὰ ποιοῦσι τὸν οὐρανὸν ἔχειν ὡς συμπεσόντε ἀνὰ τὴν γῆν”
(*Met.* Δ23, 1023a 17)

Translation: “Pillars hold, have the weight lying upon them, and, as the poets say, *Atlas holds the vault of heaven*”: having in the sense of holding, and indeed as κωλύειν (*kōlyein*, “holding off”)—“holding off another being, hindering it from being as it would like to be according to its own being, ‘according to its genuine ὁρμή (*hormē*, ‘impulse’).” The ὁρμή (*hormē*) of the weight is to fall downward; the vault of heaven “has the tendency to fall down upon the earth.” Having in this sense of holding is the holding off of another from its determinate being-possibility, which lies in its ὁρμή (*hormē*), is the συνέχον (*synechon*, “holding-together”). Συνεχές (*syneches*), “continuum,” “constancy,” is “a basic aspect of the being of things moved” (*Physics*, Book 5).

The Common Ontological Structure

“These four kinds of ἔχειν (*echein*) always mark beings with the being-character of *being after a definite being-possibility*, or its negation, which, in the case of negation, is the same as that of *holding off something from being genuinely as it would like to be*.” (p. 118)

It is no accident, Heidegger notes, that Aristotle says in conclusion: καὶ τὸ ἐν τινὶ δὲ εἶναι ὁμοτρόπως λέγεται καὶ ἐπομένως τῷ ἔχειν (*kai to en tini de einai homotropōs legetai kai hepomenōs tō echein*, *Met.* Δ23, 1023a 21) —“*Having is said in the same way as being-in-something*.” Ἐπομένως (*hepomenōs*, “following along”): “this meaning of being-in-something is already co-given with having; the character of having and being had has that of being-in-something” (p. 118).

Ἑξις (*hexis*) Among the Categories: *Metaphysics* Δ 20

It is therefore justifiable, Heidegger argues, that ἔχειν (*echein*) appears among the categories alongside κεῖσθαι (*keisthai*, “being-positioned”)—and that ἕξις (*hexis*) is to be elucidated as a mode of being-there. Aristotle in *Metaphysics* Δ 20:

“ἔξις δὲ λέγεται ἓνα μὲν τρόπον οἷον ἐνέργειά τις τοῦ ἔχοντος καὶ ἐχομένου, ὥσπερ πράξις τις ἢ κίνησις” (*Met.* Δ20, 1022b 4)

Translation: “ἔξις (*hexis*) is the ἐνέργεια (*energeia*, ‘being-at-work,’ ‘actuality’), the genuine there, the being-present of the having and of what is had” (p. 118). The *there* is related to having—having as the having of what is having and of what is had. Within this being-context, ἔξις (*hexis*) means the *genuine being-present of having as such*.

The (metaxy, “the between”)

“ὅταν γὰρ τὸ μὲν ποιῇ τὸ δὲ ποιῆται, ἔστι ποίησις μεταξὺ: οὕτω καὶ τοῦ ἔχοντος ἐσθῆτα καὶ τῆς ἐχομένης ἐσθῆτος ἐστι μεταξὺ ἔξις” (*Met.* Δ20, 1022b 5)

Translation: “When the one does something, the other is done; thus the *doing* as such is the μεταξὺ (*metaxy*), the *between*. There is also a between in the case of having clothes on, having-on on the one side, the clothes that are put on on the other side.” The having-on as such is the ἔξις (*hexis*). This having is something *ultimate*: nothing more can be had on its part—Aristotle observes that we cannot say that the having of clothes leads to a new being-determination, “but rather simply the there, the being-present.” The clothes “*are* what constitutes the genuine there of the clothes,” in being put on, when they reach their τέλος (*telos*, “end,” “completion”).

Ἐξις (*hexis*) as Διάθεσις (*diathesis*) and Τάξις (*taxis*): *Metaphysics* Δ 19

Aristotle further characterizes ἔξις (*hexis*) as διάθεσις καθ’ ἣν ἢ εὖ ἢ κακῶς διακείται (*diathesis kath’ hēn ē eu ē kakōs diakeitai*, *Met.* Δ20, 1022b 10)—“an allotment according to which something is well or badly disposed.” Διάθεσις in Chapter 19 is having as a τάξις (*taxis*, “allotment,” “ordering”): “an allotment that has the character of θέσις (*thesis*, ‘positing’)”—a *posited* allotment, “not a merely accidental being-thrown-together, but a being-positing.” Διακείσθαι (*diakeisthai*) is related to μεταβάλλειν (*metaballein*, “changing-over”), “which happens through the πάθη (*pathē*)” (p. 119).

“The ἔξις (*hexis*) as διάθεσις (*diathesis*), as τάξις (*taxis*), springs from προαίρεσις (*proairesis*, ‘resolution,’ ‘choice’): the proper finding-oneself in the being-allotted of the moment.” (p. 119)

The Culminating Definition of §17a

“Ἐξις (*hexis*) is the *determination of the genuineness of being-there in a moment of being-composed as to something*: the various ἔξεις (*hexeis*) as the various modes of being able to be composed. Ἐξις (*hexis*) is, in an entirely fundamental way, the being-determination of genuine being, here in relation to human πράξις (*praxis*, ‘action’). Πράξις (*praxis*) is characterized through ἀρετή (*aretē*), and ἀρετή (*aretē*) is characterized as ἔξις προαιρετική (*hexis proairetikē*). Πράξις (*praxis*), as the how of being-in-the-world, appears here as the being-context that we can also designate in another sense as *existence*.” (p. 119)

The orientation toward καιρός (*kairos*, “the right moment”) emerges directly:

“Being-composed is not something optional and indeterminate, for in ἔξις (*hexis*) lies the primary orientation toward the καιρός (*kairos*): ‘I am there, come what may!’ This being-there, being-on-the-alert in one’s situation, in relation to its matter, characterizes ἔξις (*hexis*).” (p. 119)

And—decisively for the link to §18— $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*) is intrinsically related to its negation:

“ $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*) is, therefore, a being-possibility that is *related in itself to another possibility*, to the possibility of my being, *that within my being something comes over me, which brings me out of composure*.” (p. 119)

§17b. Presentation of the Context of the Treatment of $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*)

pp. 119–121 (Presentation) · §17c.

and

· pp. 121–122 (Four Basic Aspects)

[Translator’s note: Heidegger’s lecture-text labels this transitional material as “b) Presentation of the Context of the Treatment of $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ ” (p. 119) and then “c) $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ and ἀρετή” (p. 121). The structured manifest collapses these into §17b. Both sub-rubrics are preserved here.]

The Hermeneutic Function of $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*)

Heidegger summarizes: $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*) plays a fundamental role in the Aristotelian analysis of being but also becomes important for another basic determination—Aristotle discusses στερήσις (*sterēsis*, “privation”) in opposition to $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*) and in detail with κίνησις (*kinēsis*). The task is to understand the πάθη (*pathē*) as those determinations that “characterize the audience in a definite situation” (p. 120). The audience is in a definite situation over against the speaker; this situation becomes co-determinative of how the audience understands. The πάθη (*pathē*) are topics insofar as they are co-decisive for the manner and mode of λέγειν (*legein*, “speaking”); the λόγος (*logos*) has its basis in the πάθη (*pathē*) themselves.

“To take hold of what is meant by πάθη (*pathē*) in the right way, we are choosing a roundabout path toward $\acute{\epsilon}\xi\iota\varsigma$ (*hexis*), by way of a general hermeneutic guide.” (p. 120)

Three Questions for Every Πάθος (*pathos*): Rhetoric B 1, 1378a 24

Aristotle, Heidegger notes, “considers the affectus in three respects” (p. 121):

1. Πῶς διακαίμενοι εἰσὶν (*pōs diakeimenoi eisin*): “How do we find ourselves genuinely? What sort is our being-in-the-world, when we are in a rage, when we are in fear, when we feel pity?”
2. Ποίαις (*poiais*): “About what do we get angry, lose composure?”
3. Ἐπὶ ποίοις (*epi poiois*): “In relation to whom, in encountering which sort of human beings, are we there in this way?”

The three questions disclose “the basic structure of the πάθη (*pathē*)”: the orientation toward being-with-one-another of being-there as being-in-the-world (p. 121). [This threefold structure is the proto-form of the threefold structure of attunement (*Stimmung*) in *Being and Time* §29: how one finds oneself, what one is attuned to, with respect to whom.]

Historical Excursus: The Doctrine of the Affects from Aristotle to Dilthey

Heidegger interrupts the systematic argument with a substantial historical aside (pp. 120–121). The Aristotelian doctrine of the πάθη (*pathē*) had “quite an effect on subsequent philosophers and theologians (e.g., Thomas’s

doctrine of affects), both for its fundamental orientation and its selection of phenomena. Generally, the πάθη (*pathē*) are a basic question of theology” (p. 120).

Figure	Locus / Contribution
Thomas Aquinas	Doctrine of <i>affectus</i> ; medieval theological orientation
Luther	Φόβος (<i>phobos</i>) connected to faith; <i>Sermo de poenitentia</i> ; <i>timor servilis</i> (servile fear) vs. <i>timor castus</i> (chaste fear); <i>attritio</i> vs. <i>contritio</i> . <i>Timor castus</i> : “pure fear in the presence of God”; <i>timor servilis</i> : fear of punishment, of hell.
Augustine	<i>De diversis quaestionibus octoginta tribus</i> , qu. 33; <i>De civitate Dei</i> XIV,5 ff.; the writings on Pelagianism
Johannes Damascenus	<i>De fide orthodoxa</i> II
Gregory of Nyssa	Περὶ φύσεως ἀνθρώπου (<i>Peri physeōs anthrōpou</i> , “On the Nature of the Human Being”)
Nemesius	Περὶ κατασκευῆς ἀνθρώπου (<i>Peri kataskeuēs anthrōpou</i>); contains the doctrine of the πάθη from the Stoa; one of the primary sources for the medieval era
Dionysius the Areopagite	<i>De divinis nominibus</i>
Dilthey	<i>Weltanschauung und Analyse des Menschen seit Renaissance und Reformation</i> — the sole modern author to have given the πάθη “thorough treatment”

Heidegger’s polemical conclusion: “The whole development of the doctrine of the affects, up to the present, has not been analyzed philosophically” (p. 120). The πάθη (*pathē*), “in an entirely general way, are characteristic of a disposition of human beings, a how of being-in-the-world” (p. 120).

Ἕξις (*hexis*) and Ἀρετή (*aretē*): Four Basic Aspects of Being-There

Heidegger now turns to *Nicomachean Ethics* Book 2, Chapters 1–5: “only that which is most important for demonstrating Ἕξις (*hexis*) to you, and at the same time, for clarifying a basic concept of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, the μεσότης (*mesotēs*)” (p. 121). The crucial preliminary disambiguation:

“Μεσότης (*mesotēs*) is not some kind of ‘mediocrity,’ not a determination of human actions in which it would amount to mediocrity, not a so-called ‘bourgeois morality,’ not a principle of ‘ranking values’; but rather a *basic relation to* (hexis), and so to the being-there of human beings, to πράξις (*praxis*), and so to the καιρός (*kairos*). The *Nicomachean Ethics* is altogether different from the ethics of a mediocre averageness and from the conventional.” (p. 121)

From the connection between ἑξις (*hexis*) and ἀρετή (*aretē*), “four basic aspects of being-there result” (pp. 121–122):

1. Πράξις (*praxis*) is concern. “Πράξις (*praxis*), ‘action,’ concern is in itself the concern of the being-there which is concerned. In being involved in the world, in dealing with it, in occupying oneself with other human beings, being-there itself, which is involved in this way, is concerned with itself, with its being. *Being-there as concern is care about itself*, for the most part inexplicitly. This basic phenomenon is hidden in the concept of ἑξις (*hexis*)—ἑξις as the having of something, the mode of being in having, the mode of being-positioned in relation to what is had.” [proto-*Sorge*]
2. Particularity. “In ἑξις (*hexis*), being-there will show itself more precisely in its *particularity*. The being of human beings, human being as being-there, is *particular, at the moment*: ἑξις (*hexis*) is a being-composed of being-there, oriented toward the moment.” [proto-*Jemeinigkeit*]
3. Being-oriented toward the moment within “more or less.” “This being-composed, this being-oriented toward the moment, is the sort of possibility that has seized being-there itself *on the basis of its particular situation*. In an average way and for the most part, being-there stays within the degrees of ‘more or less,’ too much and too little.”
4. Self-cultivation in being-there itself. “On the basis of this three-fold basic structure, it is also evident that ἑξις (*hexis*) is a basic determination of being-there itself, that the γένεσις (*genesis*) of this ἑξις (*hexis*), the manner and mode in which being-there itself comes to a being-composed in relation to itself, can have the opportunity and the type of its cultivation only, again, *in being-there itself*. Being-there must, *for itself*, take the opportunity to cultivate this being-composed as a possibility.”

§17b-α. The Γένεσις (*genesis*) of Ἀρετή (*aretē*)

pp. 122–124

Ἀρετή (*aretē*) as Mode of Being-There, Not Property

“Ἀρετή (*aretē*) as ἑξις (*hexis*) is not a property, not a possession brought to being-there from without, but is rather *a mode of being-there itself*. We are encountering once again, as always, the peculiar category of the *how*. Ἀρετή (*aretē*) is a how of being-there, not as a fixed property, but rather as the how of being-there *determined by its being*, characterized by *temporality*, by the stretching across time. For this reason, ἀρετή (*aretē*) is and comes to be δι’ ἐθους (*di’ ethous*), ‘through habit.’” (p. 122; cit. NE B 1, 1103a 25)

Cultivation Through Χρησάμενοι Ἐσχομεν (*chrēsamenoi eschomen*)

The possibilities of being-composed are graspable “only by way of *undergoing* various situations involving risk” (p. 122). The opportunity of cultivating this how of being-there is called for “only by way of not retreating from life’s possibilities and risks.”

“We make use of ἑξίς (*hexis*) since we make use of actions and of concern in the manner and mode of *finding*, first and foremost we appropriate ἑξίς (*hexis*), and not the other way around, having it as a possession so as to then make use of it, but rather χρῆσάμενοι ἐσχομεν (*chrēsamenoi eschomen*, ‘using, taking-opportunities’). This undergoing, taking-opportunities or seeking-out-opportunities, is a process. Since we are with-one-another, in the process of dealing with human beings, we come to be steady and level-headed. Since we bring ourselves into situations involving risks, we have the possibility of learning courage, of leaving cowardice behind, not in a fantasized reflection upon being-there, but rather in *venturing-out into being-there* according to the possibilities of existence as encountered.” (pp. 122–123; cit. NE B 1, 1103a 30)

No Παραγγελία (*paraggelia*) — No Universal Prescription

“οὔτε γὰρ ὑπὸ τέχνη οὐθὲ ὑπὸ παραγγελίαν οὐδεμίαν πίπτει, δεῖ δὲ αὐτοὺς αἰεὶ τοὺς πράττοντας τὰ πρὸς τὸν καιρὸν σκοπεῖν” (NE B 2, 1104a 7)

Translation: “Nor is there a παραγγελία (*paraggelia*) for this—something like a universal military field order, an a priori ethics, by which humanity becomes better *eo ipso*. Everyone must have, for himself, his eyes trained on that which is at the moment and which matters to him.” (p. 123)

The Circularity Problem and the Τέχνη Analogy

Heidegger acknowledges the difficulty: “what, in general, does it mean to become just through acting justly? Of course, I must already be just to act justly” (p. 123). Aristotle resolves this in NE B 3 by recourse to relations of a different sort, in τέχνη (*technē*, “craft,” “skill”): in τέχνη (*technē*), it depends upon the γιγνόμενα (*gignomena*, “things that come to be”) behaving in the right manner. Shoemaking depends upon the shoe, the τέλος (*telos*), the ἔργον (*ergon*, “work,” “product”), behaving in the right manner.

The decisive disanalogy:

“The being of human beings is determined in its ἔργον (*ergon*) as πράξις (*praxis*). This has the τέλος (*telos*) in itself, comes to its end through itself. For this reason, the basic conditions governing the ἔργον (*ergon*) of human beings are entirely different from those in the case of a τέχνη (*technē*). For this πράξις (*praxis*), it depends on how the one acting, as such, behaves toward himself.” (p. 123)

Three Aspects of the Πῶς ἔχον τοῦ Πράττων (*pōs echon tou prattōn*): NE B 3

The “how” of the “one acting” is defined in three aspects:

1. Εἰδώς — φρόνησις (*eidōs — phronēsis*, “knowing — prudence”): “he must be ‘knowing,’ must act in the right ‘condition of looking around,’ which is oriented toward the καιρός (*kairos*) with respect to the subject matter.” (NE B 3, 1105a 31)
2. Προαιρούμενος (*proairoumenos*, “resolving-oneself”): “he must act out of himself ‘on the basis of an actual being-resolved to...” (NE B 3, 1105a 31)
3. Βεβαίως καὶ ἀμετακινήτως ἔχων (*bebaiōs kai ametakinētōs echōn*, “stably and unshakeably having”): “Acting in such a way that he is thereby stable and not to be brought out of composure. *This recalls the determination of* (pathos) *through* (di’

hosa metaballontes); *we are brought out of one frame of mind into another.*” (NE B 3, 1105a 33; *Rhet.* B 1, 1378a 20)

What is characteristic, Heidegger underlines, “is not the resulting condition, the having-come-into-another-frame-of-mind, but rather *the having-lost-composure*, being on the way from one state to another, the peculiar unrest that is given with πάθος (*pathos*) itself in relation to φόβος (*phobos*) characterized as *ταραχή* (*tarachē*, ‘tumult,’ ‘getting mixed up’)” (p. 124; cit. *Rhet.* B 4, 1382a 21).

The Polemic Against Sophistical Λέγειν (*legein*)

These three determinations, especially the third (προαίρεσις [*proairesis*] is βεβαίως [*bebaiōs*]), “are *not ascribed* to a τέχνη (*technē*)” (NE B 3, 1105b 1). Heidegger reads Aristotle’s polemic at NE B 3, 1105b 5 sqq.:

“ἀλλε οἱ πολλοὶ ταῦτα μὲν οὐ πράττουσιν, ἐπὶ δὲ τὸν λόγον καταφεύγοντες οἴονται φιλοσοφεῖν καὶ οὕτως ἐσεσθαι σπουδαῖοι”

Translation: “Most do not show concern for this [being-προαιρούμενος-βεβαίως], but instead they resort to babble and deceive themselves, thereby, to philosophize and to be serious in the right manner. They resemble those who, while listening carefully to the doctor [and talking things over with him], nonetheless do nothing to follow his orders. Just as these others do not become healthy by sharing concern in this manner, neither do they who only moralize appropriate genuine existence for themselves [except in conversation].” (p. 124)

“What is characteristic is the sharp contrast between *about ethics-related problems* and *real philosophizing*—an advance against the misuse of Socratic method in the claim that he understood Socrates correctly, and this will not easily be contested.” (p. 124)

§17b–β. Ἀρετή (*aretē*) as Μεσότης (*mesotēs*)

pp. 124–127

The Sharpening: Ἕξις as “a How of Πάθος”

The relation of Ἕξις (*hexis*) and ἀρετή (*aretē*) is now sharpened in order to clarify, on that basis, “how Ἕξις (*hexis*) itself can be the how of our comportment toward the πάθη (*pathē*)” (p. 125).

“Ἕξις (*hexis*) is nothing other than a how of πάθος (*pathos*), being-out-of-composure, in relation to being-composed-as-to...” (p. 125)

Aristotle says, NE B 5, 1106a 13: “according to its being-origin, ἀρετή (*aretē*) is a Ἕξις (*hexis*), a being-composed as to....” Ἕξις (*hexis*) is to be understood “in relation to the concrete being of human beings.” Ἕξις (*hexis*) also has the further meaning that it is the same as δύναμις (*dynamis*, “possibility,” “potency”) of any being at all. Here, Ἕξις (*hexis*) has “the definite orientation toward the being of human beings” (p. 125).

Ζωή Πρακτική Μετὰ Λόγου (*zōē praktikē meta logou*) and the Four-fold Encountering of the World

“In itself, ἕξις (*hexis*) is related to the ζωή πρακτική μετὰ λόγου (*zōē praktikē meta logou*, ‘practical life with speech/reason’), the sort of being-in-the-world in which the world is encountered in the character of συμφέρον (*sumpheron*, ‘the conducive’), βλαβερὸν (*blaberon*, ‘the harmful’), ἡδύ (*hēdy*, ‘the pleasant’), and λυπηρόν (*lypēron*, ‘the painful’). Our being-in-the-world is always characterized by this disposition-of-being-elevated and being-burdened, specifically in a way that we find ourselves within the degrees of a bad mood or an elevated mood. Ἔξις (*hexis*) is the determinate being-composed within this way of being. In this way, ἀρετή (*aretē*) is determined in its being-character.” (p. 125)

Excursus: Ἔξις (*hexis*) as Δύναμις (*dynamis*) — Heidegger’s Three-Layered Claim

The compressed sentence at p. 125 in which Heidegger writes that “ἕξις (*hexis*) also has the further meaning that it is the same as the δύναμις (*dynamis*) of any being at all” — and that, “here, ἕξις (*hexis*) has the definite orientation toward the being of human beings” — performs a tightly compressed three-layered ontological move that warrants explicit unpacking. The three layers are not optional embellishments; they are load-bearing for everything that follows in §17b–γ and §18.

Layer 1: (hexis) is a being-determination of anything that is at all

The first layer is a claim of *universal ontological scope*. Ἔξις (*hexis*) is not a moralist’s concept restricted to ethics; it is a structure of *being* as such. This is why it appears among the categories (*Met.* Δ20, 1022b 4) and why Heidegger has spent §17a working through the four senses of εἶναι (*echēin*) in *Metaphysics* Δ23: metals, towns, basins, the vault of heaven all *have* in determinate ways. Ἔξις (*hexis*) names the settled, structural way in which any being “is after a definite being-possibility, or its negation” (p. 118).

Layer 2: Aristotle’s own equation — (hexis) is the same as (dynamis)

The second, decisive layer is that this universal ontological structure coincides with what Aristotle calls δύναμις (*dynamis*). The equation is not Heidegger’s editorial gloss; it is Aristotle’s own. In *Metaphysics* Δ20, 1022b 10 (which Heidegger has been working through immediately preceding this passage), Aristotle explicitly identifies one sense of ἕξις (*hexis*) with διάθεσις καθ’ ἣν ἢ εὖ ἢ κακῶς διακείται (*diathesis kath’ hēn ē eu ē kakōs diakeitai*) — “a disposition according to which something is well or badly disposed (διακείται, *diakeitai*).” A διάθεσις (*diathesis*) is a *settled way of being-able-to-be-affected*: precisely a δύναμις (*dynamis*). And in *Metaphysics* Δ12, 1019a 15 ff. — the locus classicus for the senses of δύναμις (*dynamis*) — Aristotle distinguishes the principal senses that converge with ἕξις (*hexis*):

ἡ δύναμις τοῦ ποιεῖν (*dynamis tou poiein*) — the *being-able-to-do* (active power);

ἡ δύναμις τοῦ παθεῖν (*dynamis tou pathein*) — the *being-able-to-undergo* (passive power);

ἡ *the fitness or aptitude* of a thing to do or undergo *well* — a normative δύναμις.

Three structural features of δύναμις (*dynamis*) make this Aristotelian equation indispensable for Heidegger’s argument:

1. Standing capacity, not occurrent state. A δύναμις is what a being *has at its disposal* even when not currently exercising it. The courageous person *is* courageous when asleep; the metal *is* in preparedness for becoming a statue even before it is cast. Δύναμις is settled *being-able-to*, not unrealized possibility waiting to

happen. This is why ἕξις (*hexis*) can be the ἐνέργεια (*energeia*, “being-at-work,” *Met.* Δ20, 1022b 4) of having: the “being-there” of the having itself, even before any further act.

2. Bivalence: receptivity and activity together. Δύναμις is *both* power-to-do *and* power-to-undergo — the same settled capacity is exercised in πράξις (*praxis*) and is liable to be struck or displaced in πάθος (*pathos*). This bivalence is structurally essential: a purely active “habit” could not be brought-out-of-composure; a δύναμις-sense ἕξις (*hexis*) precisely *can*. Without this Aristotelian equation, ἕξις (*hexis*) and πάθος (*pathos*) would have to come from different sources; with it, they are two faces of one structural capacity.
3. Preparedness toward a determinate range. Δύναμις is never bare possibility — it is always δύναμις τοῦ τοιοῦδε (*dynamis tou toioute*), “capacity for *such-and-such*.” The metal’s δύναμις to become a statue (the §17a example on p. 117) is its δεκτικόν (*dektikon*) — its being-in-preparedness for that determinate εἶδος (*eidos*, “look”). Δύναμις and δεκτικόν are two angles on the same ontological positivity that Heidegger insisted on at p. 117 (the ὕλη [*hylē*] is “not an indeterminate ‘material’ but a positive character of a mode of being-there”).

Layer 3: The narrowing — “here, has the definite orientation toward the being of human beings”

The third layer narrows the universal δύναμις-structure to the specific case Heidegger and Aristotle are pursuing. Ἕξις qua δύναμις is universally ontological; it applies to metals, plants, animals, anything that “has” a settled capacity. But the analysis of πράξις (*praxis*) and ἀρετή (*aretē*) requires that this universal structure be taken *with reference to the determinate kind of being the human being is* — namely, ζῶη πρακτική μετὰ λόγου (*zōē praktikē meta logou*). The narrowing adds three specifically human-ontological features:

- The δύναμις in question is one that can be *cultivated through* ἔθος (*ethos*, “habit”) — unlike, say, the metal’s preparedness, which is given by φύσις (*physis*, “nature”) and not subject to ethical γένεσις (*genesis*).
- The δύναμις is structured by λόγος (*logos*) — speech, articulation, deliberation — which is why ἀρετή (*aretē*) will turn out to be ἕξις προαιρετική (*hexis proairetikē*): a δύναμις borne specifically by προαίρεσις (*proairesis*, “resolution”).
- The δύναμις is bound to καιρός (*kairos*, “the right moment”) — it is a δύναμις *for seizing the situation*, not a δύναμις for producing a fixed result. This is why, ten pages later (p. 126), Heidegger glosses the μέσον (*meson*) of ἀρετή (*aretē*) as a δύναμις in the sense of κριτική (*kritikē*) — the “ability-to-separate” that αἴσθησις (*aisthēsis*) itself displays at *De Anima* B 11, 424a 4.

Why the Three-Layered Claim Carries the Whole §17 §18 Transition

The δύναμις-equation is not a marginal aside — it is the *load-bearing concept* that licenses the formula a few lines later (p. 125):

“Ἕξις (*hexis*) is nothing other than a how of πάθος (*pathos*), being-out-of-composure, in relation to being-composed-as-to...” (p. 125)

This sentence only works if ἕξις (*hexis*) is read as a δύναμις (*dynamis*) in the bivalent Aristotelian sense. Because δύναμις is intrinsically *both* active power and passive power, ἕξις (*hexis*) and πάθος (*pathos*) can be *co-originary structures of the same human being-in-the-world*: the same settled capacity that is exercised as πράξις (*praxis*, the ἐνέργεια of having) is what is *struck, displaced, or brought out of composure* in πάθος (*pathos*, the πάσχειν of having). Heidegger’s entire interpretation of human being-there as the dialectic of composure and being-

taken depends on Aristotle having already, in *Metaphysics* Δ20, treated ἕξις and δύναμις as the same ontological region.

Compressed reformulation of the p. 125 sentence: *(hexis) is, in its widest sense, the same structural region that Aristotle calls (dynamis) — the settled, bivalent capacity-to-be-such-and-such that any being possesses; in the present context, this universal capacity-structure is taken specifically as the capacity-structure of (zōē praktikē meta logou): a cultivated through (ethos), articulated by (logos), and oriented toward (kairos).* This is what licenses everything that follows: ἀρετή as ἕξις προαιρετική, μεσότης as ἕξις βλέπουσα (“the seeing being-composed”), and the eventual co-originary pairing with πάθος.

Μεσότης (*mesotēs*): The Medical Origin and Ethical Transposition

Aristotle seeks to sharpen the being-determination of ἀρετή (*aretē*) by taking it as μεσότης (*mesotēs*)—by taking the οὐσία (*ousia*, “substance,” “being”) of ἀρετή (*aretē*) as μεσότης (*mesotēs*). “In the expression μεσότης (*mesotēs*), μέσον (*meson*) comes from medicine” (p. 125): the medical concept of health as μέσον (*meson*, “mean,” “middle”) orienting medical concept formation. Aristotle “transposed this basic concept of medicine to ethics, with a concrete glance toward the specific difference in the basic sense of being dealt with. In previous ethical questioning, the concept of the μεσότης (*mesotēs*) did not come up” (p. 125).

Two Senses of Μέσον (*meson*): Κατεαὐτὸ vs. Πρὸς Ἡμᾶς

“ἐν παντὶ δὴ συνεχεῖ καὶ διαιρετῷ ἐστὶν λαβεῖν τὸ μὲν πλεῖον τὸ δὲ ἕλαττον τὸ δὲ ἴσον” (NE B 5, 1106a 26)

Translation: “In all that holds together in itself, in all that is stable, the more or less and correspondingly the equal can be distinguished” (p. 125). And these distinctions are:

1. κατεαὐτὸ τὸ πράγμα (*kat’ auto to pragma*) — “with regard to the matter itself,” arithmetical/geometrical;
2. πρὸς ἡμᾶς (*pros hēmas*) — “in relation to us.”

Τὸ δὲ ἴσον μέσον τι ὑπερβολῆς καὶ ἐλλείψεως (*to de ison meson ti hyperbolēs kai elleipseōs*): “that which is equally far removed from both ends is addressed as μέσον (*meson*) of the matter itself” (NE B 5, 1106a 29). One can determine the mean of a thing geometrically. But insofar as the μέσον (*meson*) is to be related to the interpretation of the being of human beings, it does not pertain to a πράγμα (*pragma*) in itself, but rather insofar as it is πρὸς ἡμᾶς (*pros hēmas*), “in relation to us” (NE B 5, 1106a 32).

The Decisive Result: No Universal Norm

“For our being, characterized by particularity, no unique and absolute norm can be given. It depends on cultivating the being of human beings, so that it is transposed into the aptitude for maintaining the mean. But that means nothing other than seizing the moment. It depends on ὅτε [δεῖ] καὶ ἐφε οἷς καὶ πρὸς οὓς καὶ οὗ ἕνεκα καὶ ὡς δεῖ (*hote dei kai eph’ hois kai pros hous kai hou heneka kai hōs dei*, ‘when, in relation to which, with regard to whom, for the sake of what, and how it is necessary’).” (p. 126; cit. NE B 5, 1106b 21)

Μεσότης (*mesotēs*) as Τάξις: The “Being-Apportioned” of What Comes Up for Decision

In relation to this manifoldness of being-determinations, “maintaining the mean is what counts—not an arithmetical or geometrical mean, but mean now taken in the sense of ἕξις (*hexis*) as τάξις (*taxis*), the ‘being-apportioned’ of that which comes up for a decision. Appportioning is a matter that arises from the resolution itself: the mean is, here, not a fixed property, but a way of comporting oneself in the world” (p. 126). Aristotle designates ἀρετή (*aretē*) as τοῦ μέσου στοχαστική (*tou mesou stochastikē*): “it ‘aims at’ what maintains the mean, as being-oriented to the right appportioning, the right seizing of the moment. Μεσότης: ἕξις βλέπουσα (*mesotēs: hexis blepousa*), ‘the being-composed that sees’ and is open to the situation” (p. 126; cit. NE B 5, 1106b 9; 1106b 28).

Αἴσθησις (*aisthēsis*) as Μεσότης: De Anima B 11

In Book 2, Chapter 11 of *De Anima*, in his interpretation of αἴσθησις (*aisthēsis*, “perception”), Aristotle characterizes αἴσθησις (*aisthēsis*) itself as a μεσότης (*mesotēs*)—“perception as a μέσον (*meson*) with the character of κριτικόν (*kritikon*), of the ‘ability-to-separate’ one thing from another” (p. 126; cit. *De an.* B 11, 424a 4). This conception arises from the fact that Aristotle recognizes that the seeing of colors is always separating one definite color from another. The ability-to-see “must be a possibility that is not related to *one* object in its vicinity, but a possibility that can see both ends, dark-light, and therefore the entire range of the color manifold. It is a definite being-positioned toward possible objects, which is a δύναμις (*dynamis*) in the sense of κριτική (*kritikē*)” (p. 126).

§17b–γ. The Orientation of Ἀρετή (*aretē*) toward the Moment (Καιρός)

pp. 127–129

The Definition of Ἀρετή (*aretē*): NE B 6, 1106b 36

“ἔστιν ἄρα ἡ ἀρετὴ ἕξις προαιρετική, ἐν μεσότητι οὔσα τῇ πρὸς ἡμᾶς, ὠρισμένη λόγῳ καὶ ὡς ἀνὸς φρόνιμος ὀρίσειε” (NE B 6, 1106b 36)

Translation: “Ἀρετή (*aretē*) is a being-composed in the ability-to-resolve-oneself, in terms of the moment, as the φρόνιμος (*phronimos*, ‘the prudent one’) would define it.” In this sense, “ἀρετή (*aretē*) as μεσότης (*mesotēs*) is such that it is ‘delimited,’ that it delimits itself ‘through speaking’ with the world in the mode of a *deliberating in advance of the moment*, through the how of talking through the circumstances, so that in this delimitation the right appportionment of the moment results” (p. 127).

On the basis of μεσότης (*mesotēs*) and καιρός (*kairos*), thus understood, “it can be made clear that it is a mistake to conceive of ἀρετή (*aretē*) as completedness, as this contradicts the sense of ἀρετή (*aretē*)” (p. 127).

The Two-fold Differentiation of Ἀρετή: Διανοητική / Ἠθική

What does it genuinely mean to come into a determinate ἕξις (*hexis*)? Ἐξεις are not properties brought along with us by nature; rather, they have a determinate γένεσις (*genesis*): “δι’ ἐθους (*di’ ethous*, ‘through habit’).”

“*Habituation* is the path on which we come to ἕξις (*hexis*), to ἀρετή (*aretē*)” (p. 127). Aristotle, at the beginning of *NE* Book 2, draws the essential distinction within the manifoldness of the ἀρεταί (*aretai*):

“ἡ μὲν διανοητική [ἀρετή] τὸ πλεῖον ἐκ διδασκαλίας ἔχει [...] διόπερ ἐμπειρίας δέεται καὶ χρόνου” (*NE* B 1, 1103a 15)

Translation: “Those possibilities of comportment that also cultivate διανοεῖν (*dianoein*, ‘thinking-through’) have that which is more on the basis of communication; therefore, they require experience and time. ἡ δὲ ἡθικὴ ἐξ ἑθους περιγίνεται: *On the other hand, being-composed in a determinate passion is made our own through habituation*” (*NE* B 1, 1103a 17).

Ἐθίζειν (*ethizein*) as “Bringing-Oneself-Into-a-Determinate-Possibility”

“Ἐθίζειν (*ethizein*): bringing-oneself-into-a-determinate-possibility by way of frequently-undergoing-it. The possibility is thus, in each case, a determinate possibility, for example, in a ποίησις (*poiēsis*): the appropriation of the possibility of a completion, technique. The possibility for πράξις (*praxis*), πράξις not taken in the wide sense of ‘action’ as such, but as determination of the being of human beings.” (p. 127)

Γραμματικός (*grammatikos*): The Test Case

Aristotle speaks of the γραμματικός (*grammatikos*, “writer/grammarian”) at *NE* B 4, 1105a 22. He says: one can write correctly, at first by chance or with outside help. But whoever writes by chance cannot simply write. He must write in the way demanded by τέχνη (*technē*); he must write, not by chance, but according to a prescription; and without outside help, he must be able to write from out of himself. “Through practice, by frequently-undergoing, it comes about that being-oriented puts the prescription further and further out of play. Training has the precise sense of reducing deliberation insofar as it is through training that the completedness of attaining a *result* comes about. With τέχνη (*technē*), the ἔργον (*ergon*) is decisive” (p. 127).

Πράξις vs. Τέχνη: The How vs. the Result

“In the case of an *action*—in the narrow sense in which it is opposed to ποίησις (*poiēsis*)—it does not, according to its sense, depend on the action simply ending, on a result coming about; instead, προαίρεσις (*proairesis*) is decisive, the manner and mode of ‘resolving oneself.’ It belongs to action that it arise in each case out of a *resolution*. Action itself has its τέλος (*telos*) in the καιρός (*kairos*). Therefore, it belongs to action that it *proceed by way of deliberating and as such be fulfilled*. In ὀρθότης (*orthotēs*, ‘correctness’), the action is fulfilled in the ‘correctness’ of deliberation. With training, the possibility of action is put out of play, deliberating and resolving, the how of action—precisely that on which it depends. Therefore, to be able to be brought into the possibility of right action does *not* mean to appropriate a completedness.” (pp. 127–128)

Repetition vs. Routine

“Repetition does not mean the bringing-into-play of a settled completedness, but rather *acting anew in every moment on the basis of the corresponding resolution*.” (p. 128)

“Cultivating ἕξις (*hexis*) never depends on an operation, a routine. *In an operation, the moment is destroyed.* Every completedness, as settled routine, breaks down in the face of the moment. Appropriation and cultivation of ἕξις (*hexis*) through habituation means nothing other than *correct repetition.*” (p. 128)

Πράξις Demands Constant Re-appropriation

Aristotle sharply distinguishes ἀρετή (*aretē*) and action from τέχνη (*technē*) in NE B 3, although he initially groups them together when demarcating them in opposition to ἐπιστήμη (*epistēmē*, “science”). To appropriation ἐκ διδασκαλίας (*ek didaskalias*, “through teaching”) belong ἐμπειρία (*empeiria*, “experience”) and χρόνος (*chronos*, “time”) (NE B 1, 1103a 15). For Aristotle, “science,” ἐπιστήμη (*epistēmē*), “is a determinate ἕξις (*hexis*), a determinate being-positioned toward the matter that is there as such, in such a way that I have information about it. This ἕξις (*hexis*) carries in itself a measure for concrete knowing” (p. 128). According to its content, this concrete knowing “can only be brought forward little by little. It is dependent upon the extent of knowing. It requires in itself a fully determinate duration.” By contrast, πράττειν (*prattein*), “action,” as well as ποιεῖν (*poiein*), “completing,” must be cultivated as such in πράξις (*praxis*) and τέχνη (*technē*). They do not take up a definite material, but rather *cultivate the how of dealing itself.*

“The how is only appropriated in such a way that the human being enables himself *to be composed at each moment*; not routine but holding-oneself-open, δύναμις (*dynamis*) in the μεσότης (*mesotēs*). All of human living cannot be there constantly. The possibilities that a human existence has at its disposal are not constantly there within the stretching of being-there; it loses itself. The possibility deteriorates, and being-there requires ever new and constantly repeated appropriation.” (p. 128)

The Always (Ἄει) of Being-There as the Frequently (Πολλάκις) of Repetition

The peculiarity of that upon which it depends in repetition as a determinate practice can be characterized by the fact that all action, and all non-action, is oriented toward the μεσότης (*mesotēs*). “Aristotle emphasizes, again and again, that the μέσον (*meson*) is hard to find and easy to miss; errors are easy. To fly off the handle is easy, but to be angry at the right moment is difficult. This requires the possibility of being able to seize the moment as a whole. Therefore, acting seldom occurs on the basis of the μεσότης (*mesotēs*) and in the μεσότης (*mesotēs*)” (p. 128; cit. NE B 9, 1109a 26).

The Closing Formulation: Historicity

“The whole question of self-habituating must be seen from the look of the possibility on which appropriation depends. It depends on being-resolved at each moment, and on the appropriating of the moment. Aristotle’s saying ‘on the basis of acting-frequently’ [ἐκ τοῦ πολλάκις πράττειν, *ek tou pollakis pratein*; NE B 3, 1105b 4] is also to be understood in this way. Here, this acting-frequently does not mean often in the sense of a duration, such that it would have ultimately become routine after a determinate amount of time. Rather, it is related to πράξις (*praxis*) as προαίρεσις (*proairesis*): continual-repeating of προαίρεσις (*proairesis*). The frequently is, precisely, that which characterizes the temporality of being-there. Aristotle cannot say αἰεί (*aei*, ‘always’) insofar as human being-there does not so comport itself constantly and always. It can constantly be otherwise. The *always* of a being like being-there is the *frequently of repetition*. It is the being-there of human beings, as determined by *historicity*, to see entirely different time-contexts in relation to which the remaining time-determinations break down.” (p. 129)

This closing sentence is the philological point of origin for the existential analysis of historicity (*Geschichtlichkeit*) in *Being and Time* §72–77.

Synthetic Reading of §17

Architectural Position

§17 is the systematic hinge of Chapter 3. §13–14 established πίστις (*pistis*, “credence”) and the rhetorical analytic; §15–16 located ἦθος (*ēthos*) and πάθος (*pathos*) as πίστεις; §17 now grounds πάθος (*pathos*) ontologically by working through its co-originary structure, ἕξις (*hexis*). §18 will then return to πάθος (*pathos*) with the “hermeneutic clue” that §17 has provided. The key formula linking the two: “Ἔξις (*hexis*) is nothing other than a how of πάθος (*pathos*)” (p. 125).

Six Theses Heidegger Establishes

1. Ἔξις (*hexis*) is a fundamental concept of being, derived from ἔχειν (*echein*) as a category. The four senses of ἔχειν (*echein*) (*Met.* Δ23) all express *being after a definite being-possibility*. (§17a)
2. ὕλη (*hylē*) is not indeterminate “material” but a *positive mode of being-there*: being-in-preparedness (δεκτικόν, *dektikon*). (§17a)
3. Ἔξις (*hexis*) is the determination of the genuineness of being-there in a moment of being-composed; it carries the orientation toward καιρός (*kairos*) and is intrinsically related to its negation in πάθος (*pathos*). (§17a)
4. Ἀρετή (*aretē*) is not a property but a mode of being-there, characterized by temporality, with its γένεσις (*genesis*) only in being-there itself—not deliverable by τέχνη (*technē*) or παραγγελία (*paraggelia*). (§17b–α)
5. Μεσότης (*mesotēs*) is not mediocrity but the structural relation πρὸς ἡμᾶς (*pros hēmas*); for human being there is no mean κατ’ αὐτό (*kat’ auto*); the mean is a *seizing of the moment*, an ἕξις βλέπουσα (*hexis blepousa*, “seeing being-composed”). (§17b–β)

6. The always of being-there is the frequently of repetition; ἀρετή (*aretē*) demands acting-anew at each moment, not routine; the temporal character of being-there is *historicality*. (§17b–γ)

Connections to *Being and Time* (1927)

- ∘ Εξίς, Befindlichkeit (BT §29): “the determination of the genuineness of being-there in a moment of being-composed” (p. 119) is the proto-formulation of attunement.
- ∘ The four basic aspects, Sorge / Jemeinigkeit (BT §9, §41): being-there as concern hidden in the concept of having; particularity at the moment.
- ∘ Καίρως, Augenblick (BT §68): “in an operation, the moment is destroyed” (p. 128) is the 1924 form of the contrast between authentic moment-of-vision and inauthentic now.
- ∘ The frequently of repetition, Wiederholung / Geschichtlichkeit (BT §74, §72–77): the closing formulation on historicality (p. 129) is a direct anticipation.
- ∘ Πράξις as existence (p. 119): explicit equivalence; *Existenz* as “the how of being-in-the-world.”

Two Tensions Worth Flagging

1. Circularity in the genesis of ἀρετή (*aretē*): how does the initial ἐξίς (*hexis*) become possible if ἐξίς (*hexis*) requires prior ἐξίς (*hexis*)? Aristotle’s τέχνη-analogy is acknowledged as inadequate by Heidegger, but the circle is left unresolved.
2. Repetition vs. routine: Heidegger insists that *genesis* is “acting anew in every moment,” not the building of routine—yet Aristotle’s ἐθίζειν (*ethizein*) and the γραμματικός (*grammatikos*) example seem to involve precisely the kind of routine-building Heidegger rejects. The tension between Heidegger’s existential reading and Aristotle’s practical pedagogy persists.

Source Inventory

Source	Path
Primary text (book pp. 116–128; PDF pp. 131–143)	corpus/rhetorical_ontology/Heidegger, Martin - Basic Concepts of Aristotelian Philosophy_(2009)_[Clean Copy].pdf
Phase 2 structured analysis	corpus/index/Heidegger - Basic Concepts of Aristotelian Philosophy/bcap-analysis/phase2-u-fp3c.md
Structured manifest (§17–§18)	corpus/index/Heidegger - Basic Concepts of Aristotelian Philosophy/bcap-structured/u-fp3c.json

Aristotelian primary texts cited in §17 (per Heidegger’s footnotes 181–231): *Rhet.* B 1, 1378a 24; *Rhet.* B 4, 1382a 21; *Rhet.* B 4, 1105b 20; *Met.* Δ 19, 1022b 1–2; *Met.* Δ 20, 1022b 4–10; *Met.* Δ 23, 1023a 8–23; *Phys.* E 3, 226b 18; *NE* B 1, 1103a 15–30; *NE* B 2, 1104a 7; *NE* B 3, 1105a 17–b 5; *NE* B 5, 1105b 19; *NE* B 5, 1106a 13–b 28; *NE* B 6, 1106b 36; *NE* B 9, 1109a 26; *De an.* B 11, 424a 4.